

MANAGER ACTIVATION PLAYBOOK

Practical Guides

For Managers · 2026 · Confidential

Practical Guides

These field guides are short, action-oriented tools built around specific manager tasks. Read them in any order, skip around, or work through all of them at once. Come back to any guide whenever you need it.

Not sure where to start? Use this:

Workflow Mapping Guide: If you're trying to figure out where your team should use AI.

AI Work Quality Review Guide: If you want to know whether AI is actually making your team's work better.

Using AI to Think Through Problems: If you want to use AI to think through a problem, a decision, or a strategy.

Manager Conversation Guide: If you want to get better at talking to your team about AI, setting expectations, coaching, or recognizing wins.

Reusable Asset Guidance: If you want to build a library of prompts, templates, and examples your team can reuse over time.

Improving the Work

Three guides to help you identify AI opportunities, evaluate quality, and think through problems with AI.

Workflow Mapping Guide

Why It Matters

Most AI adoption stalls because people don't know where to start. The instinct is to look for a tool first. The better instinct is to look at the work first. Where does your team spend time on things that are repetitive, inconsistent, or slower than they should be? That's where AI tends to create the most value, and workflow mapping is how you find it.

What Good Looks Like

A manager who does this well can point to a specific workflow their team runs regularly, name where it slows down or gets inconsistent, and describe at least one place AI could realistically help. They've tried it, they know what changed, and they have something reusable to show for it. They're not trying to AI-enable everything at once. They picked one workflow, improved it, and built from there.

Good workflow candidates are repeatable, time-consuming or high volume, information-heavy, quality-dependent, or currently manual and recreated from scratch each time.

How To Do It

- 1. Pick one workflow.** Start with something your team does at least weekly or monthly, not the most complex process you have.
- 2. Break it into major steps.** Write down what actually happens, in order, not the ideal version.
- 3. Find the friction.** Where does it slow down? Where do people wait, search, redo, or guess?
- 4. Identify AI opportunities.** Look at friction points involving gathering information, synthesizing, or drafting something pattern-based.
- 5. Prioritize one improvement.** Pick the highest-impact, most feasible opportunity and run a sprint on it.

Manager Prompts

- Walk me through exactly what you do when you start this task. What's the first thing you open?

- Where do you find yourself doing the same thing over and over?
- What part of this would you automate if you could?
- Where does this process produce the most inconsistent results?
- If this took half the time, what would you do with the rest?

Example

A marketing manager notices her team spends 90 minutes each week pulling performance data from three platforms and writing commentary for the weekly report. The data gathering is manual, the formatting is repetitive, and the commentary follows a pattern. She maps the workflow, builds a prompt template for the formatting and drafting, and total time drops from 90 minutes to 25. The recovered time goes toward analysis they previously skipped.

Quick Reference Checklist

Use this while you're mapping the workflow with your team.

- Picked one workflow that's repeatable and time-consuming
- Described what actually happens, not the ideal version
- Found at least two friction points
- Identified a realistic AI opportunity
- Prioritized one improvement and scheduled a sprint to act on it

AI Work Quality Review Guide

Why It Matters

AI makes work faster. The real measure is whether it's making work better. You want outputs that are sharper, and more insightful, and effective than what your team was producing before, not just quicker to produce.

That means evaluating differently. Asking, "is this actually better than what we'd have produced without it." A single output can look great while the overall process creates new problems, so it's worth checking whether the approach scales or just shifts the bottleneck elsewhere.

What Good Looks Like

A manager who does this well evaluates AI-assisted work the same way they'd evaluate any work. They set aside how it was made and ask: is this better, and specifically how? They catch work that's technically fine but hasn't actually improved, and they use what they notice to coach their team toward stronger outputs over time.

Look across accuracy, clarity, insight, completeness, actionability, and creativity, depending on what matters most for the type of work.

How To Do It

- 1. Define what better looks like before you review.** What would a strong version of this look like?
- 2. Evaluate the output on its own merits.** Does it meet the bar? Where does it fall short?
- 3. Compare to the previous baseline.** Better in what way, and by how much?
- 4. Check whether the process scales,** or whether it just moves the bottleneck to review and approval.
- 5. Give specific feedback** tied to what's missing, not just "make it better."

Manager Prompts

Questions to ask yourself or your team when reviewing AI-assisted work.

- Judge this the way you'd judge any piece of work. Is it actually better than what we'd have produced before?
- What's specifically stronger here? What's still missing?
- Did AI sharpen the thinking, or just make it look more polished?
- Does speeding this up create more work for whoever reviews or approves it next?

Example

A merchandising analyst's AI-drafted reports get cleaner formatting but the insight doesn't improve, they describe what happened without saying why or what to do about it. Her manager flags it directly, and they revise the prompt to explicitly ask for a "so what" and a recommendation. The next draft is sharper, and the revised prompt goes into the asset library.

Quick Reference Checklist

Use this when reviewing AI-assisted work with your team

- Defined what a strong output looks like before reviewing
- Evaluated on its own merits, then compared to baseline
- Checked whether the approach scales or shifts the bottleneck
- Gave specific feedback and flagged strong examples for reuse

Using AI to Think Through Problems

Why It Matters

The biggest opportunity for AI is early, while you're still figuring out the problem, the approach, or the decision. Used this way, AI sharpens your judgment rather than replacing it.

What Good Looks Like

A manager who does this well brings AI into a problem before deciding what to do about it. They use it to stress-test their reasoning, explore options they might dismiss too quickly, or get a clearer picture of a messy situation. They don't outsource the thinking, they use AI to think harder.

How To Do It

- 1. Describe the situation before asking for a solution.** What's the problem, what do you know, what have you already ruled out?
- 2. Ask it to push back.** What are the weaknesses here? What am I not seeing?
- 3. Use it to explore options and tradeoffs honestly,** not to make the decision for you.
- 4. Stress-test before you commit.** Where does this fall apart?
- 5. Keep the judgment.** The response is a starting point, not an answer.

Manager Prompts

- "Here's a problem I'm trying to solve: [describe]. What am I not considering?"
- "Here's my current thinking: [describe]. What are the weaknesses in this approach?"
- "I'm deciding between these two options: [describe]. What are the real tradeoffs?"
- "Here's a plan I'm about to share with my team. Where does this fall apart?"

Example

Before a quarterly business review, a manager wants to make a case for shifting her team's resourcing. She describes the situation to AI, shares her argument, and asks what a skeptic would say. It surfaces two objections she hadn't addressed. She builds those into her prep, and the conversation goes better because she walked in ready.

Quick Reference Checklist

Use this when bringing a problem or decision to AI)

- Described the situation with enough context to be useful
- Asked AI to push back, not just support your thinking
- Explored tradeoffs and stress-tested before committing
- Kept the judgment and the decision

Leading the Team

One guide to help you have the right conversations, set expectations, and coach your team through AI adoption.

Manager Conversation Guide

Why It Matters

How managers talk about AI with their teams determines whether it takes hold. A manager who sets clear expectations and responds well when things don't go as planned creates a team that improves. These conversations also connect to AI Effectiveness ratings this cycle, so getting them right matters, but they don't need to be long. They need to be consistent.

What Good Looks Like

A manager who does this well is direct about expectations without being heavy-handed, makes space for different reactions, and asks more than they tell. When someone shares a win, they name what was good specifically. When someone is stuck, they coach rather than solve.

How To Do It

Setting expectations: This is the conversation you have before everything else, so don't assume your team already knows what's expected. Be transparent that AI Effectiveness is being rated this cycle. Expect a range of reactions: enthusiastic, willing but unsure, and genuinely concerned, and more. Make room for all of them. Point your team to the Weekly AI Learning Hour, AI Office Hours, and Start.ai.

Team meetings: Two to three minutes, weekly, is enough. The goal is to keep AI visible and normal, not to run a formal review. Recognize wins specifically and flag reusable assets when you hear about them.

1:1s: Focus on the work, not the concept of AI use. Not every 1:1 needs this, but checking in regularly early on keeps people from quietly falling behind. Coach toward one concrete next step rather than pushing enthusiasm someone doesn't feel.

Psychological safety: People won't experiment if they don't feel safe trying. Share your own AI misses and respond to failed experiments with curiosity, not correction. Know the guardrails and share them clearly: never put customer data, financials, or confidential material into unapproved tools; check first on sensitive or unreleased material; brainstorming, research, and approved-tool writing help are fine to explore freely.

Manager Prompts

Setting expectations:

- "I want to talk about where we are with AI and what I'm expecting going forward."
- "AI Effectiveness is being rated this cycle. I want you to hear that from me directly."

Team meetings:

- "Any AI wins from this week worth sharing?"
- "What did you try that didn't quite work?"

1:1s:

- "Where have you been using AI lately? What's working, what's frustrating?"
- "What would help you make more progress here?"

Psychological safety:

- "Trying something and having it not work out is completely fine."
- "Here's something I tried recently that didn't work..."

Example

A manager inherits a team with mixed AI adoption. She opens with a direct, low-pressure conversation about expectations and resources. Over the following weeks she asks one AI question per team meeting, coaches a hesitant team member through a low-stakes trial in a 1:1, and treats a team member's tone-deaf AI-drafted email as a shared lesson rather than a mistake to call out. Adoption spreads without anyone feeling pressured.

Quick Reference Checklist

Use this as an ongoing check on how you're leading AI conversations with your team.

- Set expectations directly, including that AI Effectiveness is being rated
- Asking at least one AI question per team meeting
- Coaching 1:1s based on the work, not the concept of AI
- Reinforced psychological safety and reviewed the guardrails

Building for Reuse

One guide to help you build a library of prompts, templates, and examples your team can reuse over time.

Reusable Asset Guidance

Why It Matters

Individual AI wins compound across a team only when what one person figures out gets saved somewhere others can find it. A shared asset library turns one-off solutions into standing practice.

What Good Looks Like

A manager who does this well only saves what gets reused. They store things where the team already works, not in a separate system nobody checks, and they treat the library as something the team returns to, not a folder built once and forgotten.

How To Do It

- 1. Watch for repeat use.** If a prompt gets used more than a couple times, it belongs in the library.
- 2. Turn frequent prompts into something more permanent,** like a customGPT that already carries the context, so people just enter the specifics.
- 3. Store the output, not the conversation.** Save the finished artifact in SharePoint like any other document. The exception is an ongoing, diary-style use case where the conversation itself builds over time.
- 4. Come in with a starting point.** Explore AI yourself before rolling this out so your team has something to follow.
- 5. Tie library review to a rhythm you already have,** like your monthly working session.

Manager Prompts

- Is there anything from this week worth saving or sharing?
- Is this something you'd use again, or was it a one-time fix?
- Would this be more useful as a customGPT than a prompt you retype each time?

Example

A merchandising analyst keeps rewriting the same prompt to summarize weekly data. Her manager notices the pattern and suggests turning it into a customGPT that already knows the report format. The manager flags it in the team meeting, and another analyst adopts it the same week.

Quick Reference Checklist

Use this when deciding whether something belongs in your team's asset library.

- Identified a prompt or process getting reused regularly
- Decided whether it's worth a customGPT or just a saved template
- Stored the output where the team already keeps documents
- Tied library review to an existing team rhythm